

Q: When you started your career, your education and your background did not set yourself up to be a top-level banker, did it? How did banking happen? Was it part of a plan, or was it almost by accident that you stumbled into it?

A: It wasn't part of the plan at all. By the time I left school, I was very keen to study medicine... ours was the first batch of the Joint Entrance Exams, where I managed to secure a spot. But then, when I went around looking at the facilities, I found that the college had no women's hostel. So, I would have to stay outside or in some working women's hostel. And frankly, the situation was such that it was just not conducive. I just couldn't do it—the hostel was so terrible. That's one of the things that still holds women back even today, the question of college accommodation. So, ultimately my father met the principal of my school and he said you put her into literature because I think she has a flair for writing. But I always wanted to have a career, and when I was completing my education, the subject of what I should do next came up. At that point of time, there were only two competitive exams where you needed nothing other than merit... One was the IAS [exams], and the other was the bank exams. When I looked at the IAS [exams], to my horror, I found that you needed knowledge of any subject up to the postgraduate level, and that had to be something other than a language. I didn't have that.

On the other hand, the banking exam was a very general kind of exam, just a paper on logic and on general knowledge and English, and I thought I could crack all three. Also, my friends in college egged me on... So I applied with so many others, and got selected. My mother asked me if I wanted to spend my entire life counting notes—that's the kind of idea people had about banking. But they also felt that this would be within an enclosed space, it would be safe, so they were fine with it. It turned out to be a long and steep learning curve and the bank did a pretty good job of polishing me.

Q: How is it to work in the private sector after spending so many decades in the public sector because you have an insider's perspective now of both? What are the essential differences? Would you say one is much better than the other, or are your loyalties still skewed towards the public sector?

A: It's very difficult to get rid of loyalties after 40 years of service, right? But there are a lot of myths about the public sector and the private sector. I keep joking with my colleagues that once I retire from here, I'm going to write a book busting these myths, because actually speaking, at the core of it all, they are very similar. However, there are some grave dissimilarities as well. For instance, in the public sector, you don't have an incen-



“This idea that the public sector doesn't work, I don't know where it stems from; because I was up till one in the night every night for the four years that I was Chairman [of the State Bank of India]”
